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Democracy Dies in Darkness

SUNDAY, MARCH 23, 2025 • \$6

Trump memo seen as threat to law firms

President looks to punish litigators who act against his aggressive policies

BY SHAYNA JACOBS

The White House is directing federal law enforcement officials to seek sanctions against attorneys or law firms that challenge President Donald Trump's actions in court, a move seen as an escalation of the president's attacks on those who oppose his aggressive policy changes or who have litigated against him in the past.

A White House memo issued late Friday night orders Attorney General Pam Bondi and Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem to pursue ethics challenges against lawyers who they accuse of bringing meritless cases or making arguments that are not backed up by fact, including in immigration courts.

The memo told Bondi to consider taking actions against law firm partners for perceived misconduct by junior attorneys and to review cases against the government from the past eight years to look for "misconduct that may warrant additional action."

The directive comes as the Trump administration faces more than 130 lawsuits over its efforts to dismantle agencies and diversity programs, freeze spending, fire federal workers and deport immigrants without due process.

Federal judges have issued about three dozen injunctions against the administration so far, while ruling in its favor in a little more than a dozen cases.

Friday's memo is part of a series of extraordinary executive actions in recent weeks that include punishing judges and lawyers who have taken positions against Trump. A continuing lawsuit over the deportation of alleged Venezuelan gang members based on the wartime Alien Enemies Act has been a particular sticking point, with the federal judge in the case calling the administration's actions "problematic and concerning."

Vanita Gupta, who served in top Justice Department posts in the Obama and Biden administrations, said the memo is a blatant threat to the justice system.

SEE TRUMP ON A8

As tensions rise on a melting map, Greenland's world stature grows

“One way or the other,” President Donald Trump has said, the United States needs to “get” Greenland. Not only to defend the homeland, but the “freedom of the world.” Denmark, he says, isn’t doing nearly enough to protect it. He has named two potential adversaries: China and Russia.

Its location, way out there, in a hostile ocean between North America, Western Europe and Russia, made Greenland strategically vital during the Cold War. After the Soviet Union collapsed, not so much.

But now, as tensions rise across a melting, militarizing Arctic, the world's largest island is back on the map.

Arctic sea ice typically reaches its greatest extent in March. It makes most of Greenland difficult to reach by ship.

Danes rush to bolster the island's defenses as Trump threatens

BY WILLIAM BOOTH AND LARIS KARKLIS
IN COPENHAGEN

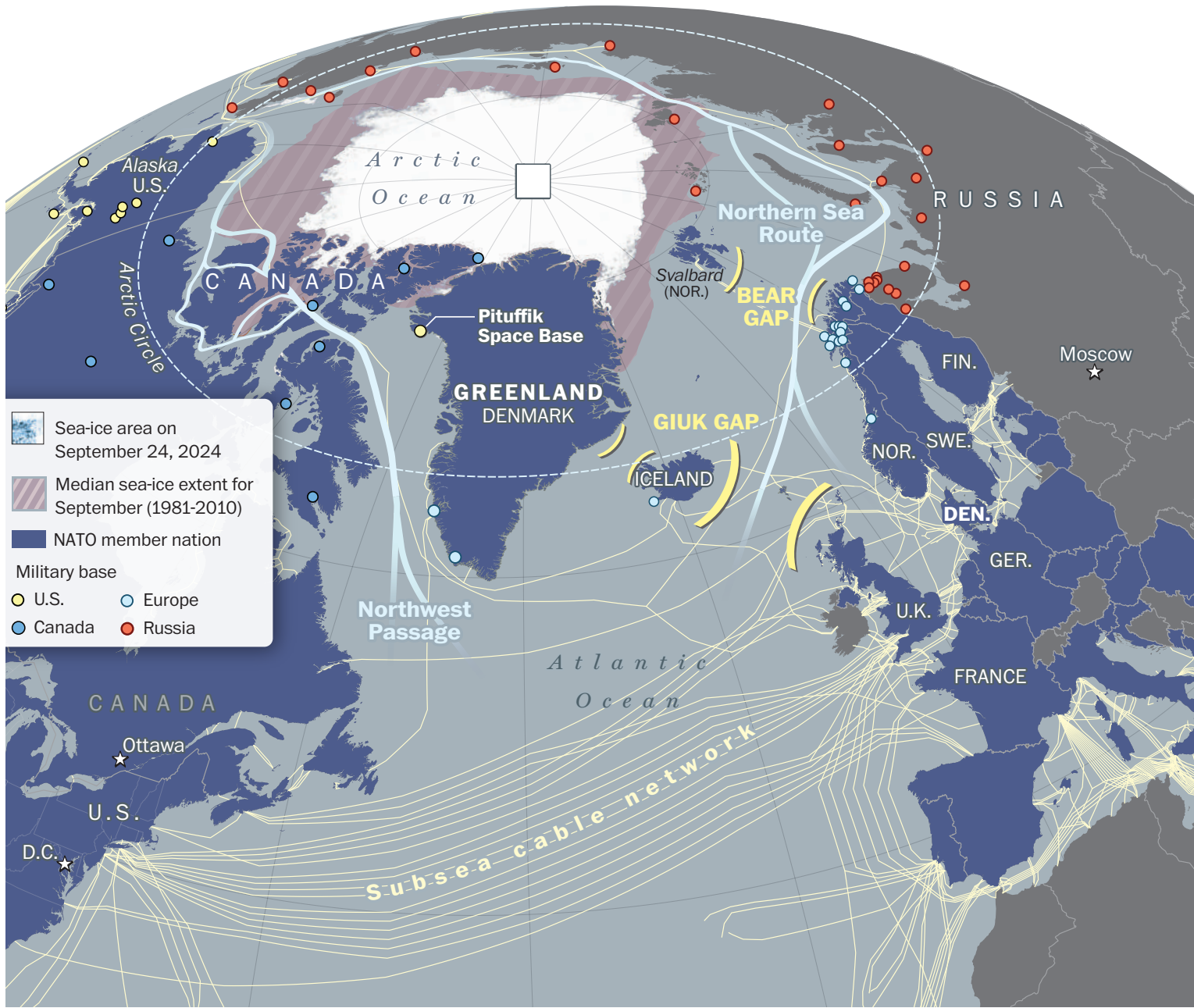
By September, the ice contracts to its smallest extent, opening passages that can shorten shipping routes.

Greenland lies along what the old Cold Warriors dubbed the “GIUK Gap,” the pinch point between Greenland, Iceland and Britain that protects the North Atlantic from Russian ships and submarines.

The island is also a waypoint for communication cables that cross the Atlantic — the kinds of cables that European defense officials say Russian “ghost ships” have been attacking by dropping and dragging their anchors across the seafloor.

Vice President JD Vance has praised Greenland’s “incredible natural resources.” Like Ukraine, the island possesses the critical and rare metals needed for the modern world

SEE GREENLAND ON A23



Sources: Minimum sea ice concentration data via the Institute of Environmental Physics at the University of Bremen. Arctic military bases via The Simons Foundation Canada. Subsea cable data via TeleGeography.

IRS on verge of migrant data deal

IN PACT, ICE COULD CONFIRM ADDRESSES

Agency would be lever in deportation campaign

BY JACOB BOGAGE AND JEFF STEIN

The Internal Revenue Service is nearing an agreement to allow immigration officials to use tax data to confirm the names and addresses of people suspected of being in the country illegally, according to four people familiar with the matter, culminating weeks of negotiations over using the tax system to support President Donald Trump's mass deportation campaign.

Under the agreement, Immigration and Customs Enforcement could submit names and addresses of suspected undocumented immigrants to the IRS to cross-reference with confidential taxpayer databases, said the people, who spoke on the condition of anonymity out of fear of professional reprisals.

Normally, personal tax information — even an individual's name and address — is considered confidential and closely guarded within the IRS. Unlawfully disclosing tax data carries civil and criminal penalties.

However, tax information may be shared with other federal law enforcement under certain, limited conditions — and typically with approval from a court. It would be unusual, if not unprecedented, for taxpayer privacy law exceptions to be used to justify cooperation with immigration enforcement, the people said.

The proposed agreement has alarmed career officials at the IRS, the people said, who worry that the arrangement risks abusing a narrow and seldom-used section of privacy law that's meant to help investigators build criminal cases, not enforce criminal penalties.

According to portions of a draft of the agreement obtained by The Washington Post, ICE access to tax data would be limited

SEE IRS ON A10

IRS turmoil: Tax revenue could fall by 10 percent, officials say. A11

Family secrets unmasked in JFK files shock and excite

Little light on the killing, but several discover their relatives were CIA assets

BY BEN BRASCH, JONATHAN EDWARDS AND WILLIAM WAN

Growing up, John Smith knew his grandfather as a serious academic — a bespectacled professor at the University of Maryland who wrote books on pre-Civil War presidents. He also knew E.B. Smith had traveled the world in his younger years.

What he didn't know until this week is that his grandfather had once been a U.S. government asset, feeding Soviet-era intelligence to the CIA.

The Trump administration's release of more than 77,000 pages related to the 1963 assassination of President John F. Kennedy has thus far shed little new light on the killing. But the unmasking of many previously redacted names has revealed the identities of people who worked with the clandestine services, roles that in many cases were hidden for decades even from close family members.

Some families are learning for the first time how parents, grandfathers or spouses participated in American spy craft — as a CIA informant gathering intelligence on Fidel Castro's supporters, a field agent planting bugs at a Chinese agency, a scholar extracting morsels of intelligence from a Soviet official.

For John Smith, the news of his grandfather's work came in the form of two short pages that could easily be missed amid this week's avalanche of papers: A newly unredacted account from 1991 of E.B. Smith pressing a KGB official for Soviet intelligence related to Kennedy's killing.

SEE SPIES ON A12



DESIREE RIOS/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Arrested at an ICE check-in, then gone without a trace

Lack of information about Alien Enemies Act deportations is nearly unprecedented, lawyers say

BY ARELIS R. HERNÁNDEZ AND MARÍA LUISA PAÚL
IN SAN ANTONIO

Henry Alborno Quintero's family had been tracking his whereabouts through an online detainee locator ever since he was arrested and put in deportation proceedings after a routine check-in with immigration officials in late January.

But on Friday — less than a week before the expected birth of his son — the Venezuelan man disappeared from the database.

“Your search has returned zero (0) matching records,” the government website states.

The families and lawyers of dozens of other Venezuelan and Salvadoran men who had been detained

by U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement say their relatives and clients have similarly disappeared over the past week, with no explanation provided by the government over where they may be.

Deportation proceedings in the United States are often shrouded in secrecy. Arrest records are not public, and detainees can be transferred to far-flung jails anywhere in the United States. But family members, lawyers and the public can get information on an inmate's whereabouts through an online database, contact with an official or direct phone communication with a detainee.

Yet in the week since the Trump administration invoked the Alien Enemies Act to deport 137 Venezuelan migrants accused of being Tren

SEE EL SALVADOR ON A17

“I’m so scared for my baby,” said Nays Ñaupari Rosila, 22, who says she can get no answers about her husband, Henry Alborno Quintero.

METRO
More than 1,400 say they were abused in Md. juvenile detention.

BOOK WORLD
Chuck Schumer's book on antisemitism may be a step behind our times.



TRAVEL
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ARTS & STYLE
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SPECIAL SECTION
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BUSINESS
More than a quarter of computer-programming jobs just vanished. Why?

COMICS.....INSERT
OBTUARIES.....A5
OPINION PAGES.....A25
WORLD NEWS.....A21

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